(literally, Lotus Message)[3] gave us a sense of what it was saying to its cadres; the *Organiser*[4] told us what the wider Sangh Parivar was talking about; and the Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram outreach outlined for us what one of the Sangh outfits working with tribal children focused on. These were compared with 1,060 articles published in the Congress magazine *Congress Sandesh*[5] from 2015 to 2019 (0.63 million words).

We compared this with politics in the online world. A similar approach was used to analyse Facebook posts of political groups and leaders. We also downloaded and analysed all Facebook posts made by the BJP, the RSS, the Congress, Narendra Modi, Amit Shah and Rahul Gandhi on their official Facebook pages between January 2016 and December 2019. Cumulatively, this amounted to 40,251 posts and 1.2 million words. Similarly, we studied the Twitter accounts of seventy-five political leaders from both the BJP and the Congress between January 2016 and December 2019: 4,76,827 posts. (See detailed methodology note in Appendix 4 at the end of this book.)

Once we cleaned up all this data and identified key issues, we created what we call the Narad Index. It measures the number of times a topic (or related keywords in English and Hindi) is mentioned per 100 words, thus allowing us to see patterns of political communication holistically. The more times a particular topic, say the Congress, is mentioned, the higher it ranks on the Narad Index. We took care to define both Hindi and English keywords for each topic.

Our guiding principle was simple: human cognition could have unconscious biases and memory is slippery. We wanted to see what the data told us. As political junkies who read everything about politics, we thought we knew all there was to know about the BJP. Yet, we were surprised by the data patterns we found and what this said about the party.

The fact is that, in election after election since 2014, both at the Union and state levels, the BJP has won more elections than it has lost because it managed to attract enough swing voters beyond its core ideological base. The BJP's core Hindu base is not enough for it to cross the winning line—like in Delhi, where it won 32.19 per cent of the vote in 2015 (38.51 per cent in 2020), but was still routed by